

THE MIDDLE EAST I

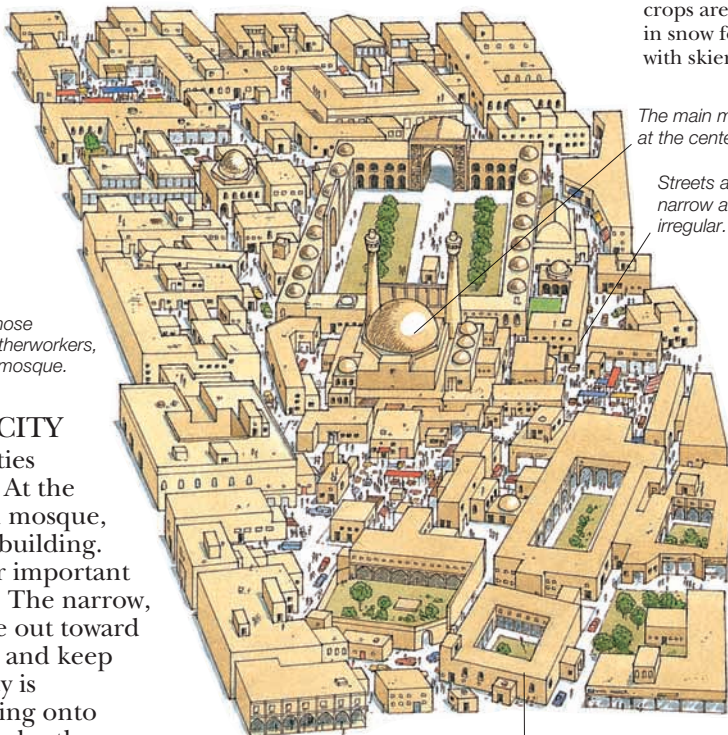
AT THE EASTERN EDGE OF THE MEDITERRANEAN SEA, this region includes the countries of Israel, Lebanon, Jordan, and Syria. It is the birthplace of some of the world's oldest civilizations and has close ties with three major religions – Judaism, Christianity, and Islam. The land is mostly dry and barren, particularly to the east, but it is lush and more fertile along the Mediterranean coast. After centuries of invasion by Arabs, Christian Crusaders, and Turks, the present-day countries took shape in the last 100 years. Since then, they have been plagued by civil wars and conflicts.



Noisy or smelly market stalls, such as those belonging to metalsmiths (above) or leatherworkers, are placed at a distance from the main mosque.

A MIDDLE EASTERN CITY

Many traditional Muslim cities follow a distinctive pattern. At the heart of the city is the main mosque, which is usually the largest building. This is surrounded by other important buildings and market stalls. The narrow, irregular streets that radiate out toward the city walls provide shade and keep down wind and dust. Privacy is important, and doors opening onto narrow streets never face each other.



The main mosque stands at the center of the city.

Streets are narrow and irregular.

Many houses face courtyards.



The market stalls selling religious goods, such as candles, incense, and books (above), are placed closest to the main mosque in the center of the city.



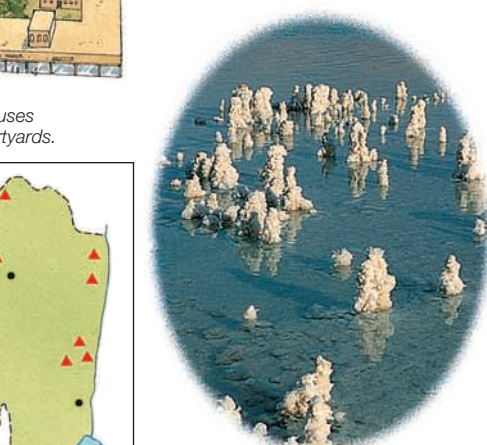
Yasser Arafat (1929–2004) was leader of the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO), which represented the interests of Palestinian Arabs.

PALESTINE

In 1948, the Jewish state of Israel was created from the country of Palestine, the ancient land of the Jews and the home of the Palestinian Arabs. Thousands of Palestinians were driven from their homes and land. Many went to live in the West Bank and the Gaza Strip. In 1967, Israel captured and occupied these areas.

After agreeing to peace accords in 1993, the Palestinians were given control over parts of these areas, and Israel intends to leave Gaza by 2006.

However, violence between the two communities continues.



THE DEAD SEA

On the border between Israel and Jordan lies a large lake known as the Dead Sea. It is the lowest place on Earth – some 1,312 ft (400 m) below sea level. Salt deposits rise up like pillars out of the water. No fish can live there, which is how the lake got its name. Mud from the shore of the Dead Sea is said to have healing properties.